two statistics. The central government had over 22 crore beneficiaries of its programmes and we got 17 crore votes in the last [2014] election. In the last [2014] election, we had 2.5 crore workers. This time [in 2019] we have 11 crore workers. We are fighting this election as a 50 per cent campaign, and you may not remember, but in states like Himachal Pradesh, Gujarat, Tripura, we crossed 50 per cent.'[15]

This was more than just a fourfold growth of the number of party workers. The manner of enrolment as much as the scale and pace suggested a new process of political mobilisation at work, where party, government records and welfare programmes each reinforced the other.

The spurt in party membership was the outcome of two major year-long enrolment campaigns: in 2014 (1 November) and 2019 (6 July).[16] It must be noted that both campaigns were launched not before but immediately after the party's election victories. This suggests more long-term aims in party-building and the creation of a system that is more than just a vote-catching machine. Importantly, the first of these, the Sadasyata Maha-Abhiyan (Mega Campaign for Membership), launched on 1 November 2014, did away with previous methods of filling paper forms to enrol members, switching entirely to digital form-filling and phone-based SMS and digital verification methods.[17] It was launched with the specific aim of increasing the party's strength fivefold in order to overtake the CCP cadre numbers.[18]

Party leaders say that each unit was given specific membership targets to meet, which were based on the votes the BJP had polled in each state in previous elections. For example, in West Bengal, BJP leaders say they had 1,44,478 members before the campaign started. Yet, the party had won 87,81,478 votes in the state in the 2014 general elections. 'Many other states had similar figures,' argue Anirban Ganguly and Shiwanand Dwivedi in a biography of Amit Shah, the party president who designed the expansion plan. He 'based his core strategy on decreasing such wide gaps'.[19] Each state-level target was fixed accordingly.